

IVE GROWTH

solutions to the problem varied from higher Central funding to more autonomy



Singh, Dikshit, Badal, Ansari, Chouhan, Gogoi, Deshmukh, Modi and Chawla

meeting next time in a village, under a tree. We talk about these things in air-conditioned halls and even at the Planning Commission meetings. I have requested the members of the commission to stay for one day and one night in a village and then they will realise what is to be done.

Our farmers do hard work. Yet they are under heavy debt. Why is it so? Because the policies of the Central government are against the farmers. Agriculture is in full control of the Centre. What can we do in the states, say about fertilisers or diesel?

Chawla: Let me ask Mr Hooda. Do you agree that agriculture is suffering because of the Central government's

"We disperse industries to rural areas, invest in education and promote tourism. All this enables job creation."

N. RANGASAMY
CHIEF MINISTER, PUDUCHERRY

anti-agriculture policy?

Bhupinder Singh Hooda, chief minister, Haryana: It is right that the farmers are not getting their due. But he has raised many points which I do not agree with. He says he is sharing natural resources; but I do not know whether he is giving me due water. Water comes from Himachal Pradesh

and Jammu & Kashmir. He talked about the Central government. But what policy did he change when he was the agriculture minister at the Centre? To criticise is very easy.

Chawla: What are you doing for agriculture? Haryana and Punjab have been feeding the country so far.

Hooda: We are feeding it even now.

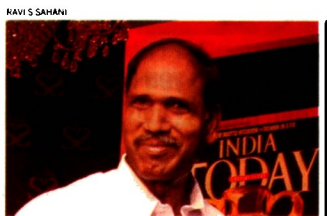
Chawla: But now their share is down.

Hooda: No, it is not down. The procurement of wheat during this season has increased. If you take the percentage, Haryana has topped in it. It performed better than Punjab. We want to empower the farmers.

Chawla: What is your demand?

Hooda: This Government has done better because it has increased the procurement price of wheat by Rs 200 per quintal. But still the farmers are not getting their due. Our country is a producer as well as a consumer. The consumers are also very poor. There should be a cap of 20 per cent or 25 per cent on, maybe, transportation or commission etc.

Chawla: I will request the finance minister to intervene here. The Punjab chief minister says the Centre is anti-farmer and does not give enough money. Do you share his views?



RAVI S. SAHANI

Chidambaram: I think you misunderstood Badal saheb when he criticised the finance minister. He was referring to my predecessors. Let us see the facts. The NDA government started with a procurement price for wheat of Rs 580 and ended at Rs 630. In the fourth year of our government, we have increased it to Rs 850.

Second, I was the finance minister in Mr Gujral's government who wrote off a part of Punjab's cost of security measures when they were fighting terrorism. I returned to government, six years later, to write off the remaining part. Therefore, the entire cost of security operations, roughly Rs 8,000 crore or so, was written off for Punjab.



"The biggest problem we should worry about is unemployment in rural areas. If this is not solved, there will be a revolution."

PARKASH SINGH BADAL
CHIEF MINISTER, PUNJAB